

FILM 12: SCREENWRITING AND VISUAL STORYTELLING



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FILM 12: Screenwriting and Visual
Storytelling

Daniel Yi

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To The Students

Getting the most out of this book

This book is a reference guide for writing screenplays. You don't need to read it in order. The five chapters cover the major components so you can feel free to jump to the section that you need clarity on.

Ch. 1 - Basics of Screenplay Formatting

An overview of what differentiates a screenplay from other storytelling mediums, including margin requirements, font choice, and layout.

Ch. 2 - Scene Headers

Covers proper formatting for scene headers, including special notations like flashbacks, dreams, etc.

Ch. 3 - Action Lines

Explains how to format action lines or on-screen action, including character introductions, use of ALL CAPS, supers, etc.

Ch. 4 - Dialogue

Details formatting for dialogue, including character cues, extension, parenthetical and more.

Ch. 5 - Transitions

A brief overview of transitions, which are primarily used in shooting scripts, included here for general knowledge.

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

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About the Author

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Daniel Yi graduated from Chapman University with an M.F.A. in film production. Before teaching, he was working as a creative director at CJ 4DPLEX. He currently teaches screenwriting and video editing at Chabot College.

About The Book

This book is designed to serve as a companion guide in your screenwriting journey. It focuses on the fundamentals of what makes a screenplay different from a novel or even a play script. Hollywood professionals have been writing scripts a certain way for a very long time. By not studying these rules, you quickly expose yourself as an amateur writer. Hollywood is heavily gatekept and your work will be tossed aside without ever being read.

But while there are some fundamental rules that cannot be broken, the guidelines are constantly evolving, especially with the introduction of technology and changing culture. Even amongst the screenwriting communities, there is discord when it comes to formatting and screenwriters tend to have their own rules. Having said that, the rules collected in this book are meant to teach you the foundational principles of screenwriting and help your script pass the litmus test of industry readers.

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1: Basics of Screenplay Formatting

In this book, you'll learn the formatting basics of writing a screenplay. While we will review some of the important requirements of a screenplay, it is highly recommended that you pick up a screenwriting software which will circumvent having to memorize a lot of these technical knowledge like margin spacing.

Screenwriting Software

There are a variety of screenwriting software available to fit your specific writing needs. For starters, here are a few recommendations:

[FinalDraft](#)

[CeltX](#)

[WriterDuet](#)

[Fade In](#)

Each have different price tags as well as their own pros and cons. Please do your research when purchasing a screenwriting software.

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1.1: Margins, Tabs and Line Spacing

Screenplays have specific margins that every writer needs to follow. The good news is that these days most people don't write with a typewriter anymore and we have screenwriting software that will figure out the margins in the screenplays for you.

Here are the basics guidelines for a Standard Screenplay Format:

- Script should be in 12-pt Courier font
- There are around 55 lines per page.
- Margin Requirements:
 - Page
 - 1.5-inch left margin
 - 1-inch right margin (between 0.5 inches and 1.25 inches)
 - 1-inch top and bottom margins
 - Page Number - 7.25" to 7.5" left margin, 0.5" top margin
 - Scene Header - 1.5" to 7.5" left margin
 - Action Lines - 1.5" to 7.5" left margin
 - Character Cue (in all caps) - 3.5" left margin
 - Parenthetical - 3.0" to 5.5" left margin
 - Dialogue - is 2.5" to 5.5" left margin
 - Transition - 6.0" left margin
- Page numbers:
 - Are in the top right corner
 - Should be flush to the right margin
 - Are half an inch from the top of the page
 - Numbers should have a period right after.
 - The first page nor the title page is numbered.
 - The second page of the script (not including the title page) is the first to have a number and it starts with 2.

See the example below for how a screenplay is formatted.

↓ 0.5"
3

Page Number
7.25" to 7.5"

Scene Header
1.5" to 7.5" → INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Character Cue
3.5" → JAMES
Can I come by tonight?

Action Lines
1.5" to 7.5" → Just then, AMY (mid-20s) walks into the house carrying grocery bags through the front door.

Startled, James hangs up immediately, places the phone on the table and turns to face her.

Dialogue
2.5" to 5.5" → JAMES (CONT'D)
Hey, you're back so soon.

Parenthetical
3.0" to 5.5" → (skeptical)
AMY
Did you not hear the car pull up in the driveway?

JAMES
No. I was watching TV. I didn't hear you.

AMY
Well, don't just sit there, James. Help me bring the groceries in. These are heavy.

James gets up and hurries to take the bags. He walks to the kitchen to put the food away.

DING!

James's phone lights up. Amy notices a text message on his phone. She peers into the kitchen to see James still putting the food away.

AMY (CONT'D)
Put the pork belly in the fridge and the rest of the meat in the freezer.

JAMES (O.S.) ← Character Cue Extension
I got it.

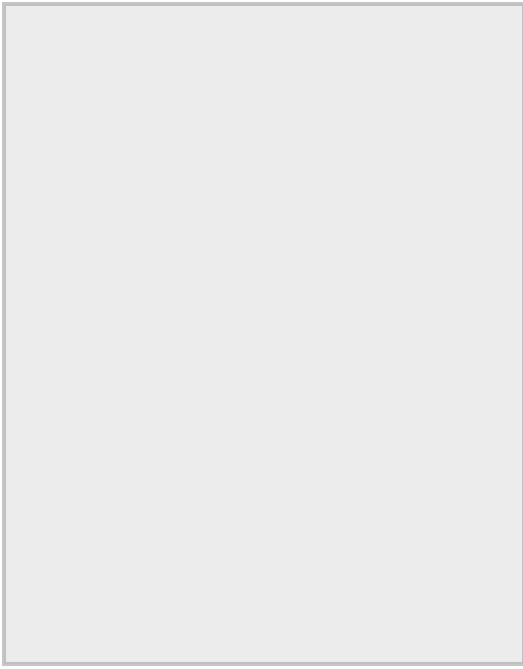
Transition
6.0" → CUT TO:

Title Page

Your title page should contain your title and your name. It may also include a draft date as well as contact information. Some screenplay contests may ask you to completely remove the name and contact information for the sake of anonymity.

The name of your project should come first followed by "written by" on a separate line underneath followed by the writer's name underneath that.

See the example below for how the title page should look:



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1.2: Screenwriting Software

While it is possible for you to write a script using Microsoft Word or Google Doc, the advantage to using a professional screenwriting software is that it handles all the margin requirements for you so you don't have to manually adjust every scene header, action line and dialogue.

There are a variety of screenwriting software available to fit your specific writing needs. Some programs offer features like cloud save, collaboration and note giving. For starters, here are a few recommendations:

[FinalDraft](#)

[CeltX](#)

[WriterDuet](#)

[Fade In](#)

Each have different price tags as well as their own pros and cons. Please do your research when purchasing a screenwriting software.

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1.3: Spec Script VS Shooting Script

Spec Script VS Shooting Script

First off, is it a *script* or a *screenplay*? The two terms are often used interchangeably but there is a difference. A script can cover a broad range of performances like film, radio and theater whereas a screenplay is specifically used for film and television.

There are 2 different types of scripts:

1. Spec Script
2. Shooting Script

A *Spec Script* is written on speculation, meaning you're hoping to sell it. There are no camera directions, editing cues, or technical jargon. The main focus is storytelling. It's primarily written for readers, which include: producers, agents or studios.

A *Shooting Script* is created after a script is sold which is used for actual shooting. It includes camera angles, shot numbers, transitions (e.g., CUT TO:), etc. The main focus is production planning. It's written for the crew: directors, directors of photography, production designers, etc.

If you are writing your script, hoping to sell it, then you will be writing a spec script. Try not to include things like scene numbers and camera directions in your spec script.

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1.4: Five Main Components of a Screenplay

There are five main parts to a screenplay that you should pay careful attention to:

1. Scene Header (Pink)
2. Action Line (Blue)
3. Character Cue (Red)
4. Dialogue (Green)
5. Transition (Orange)

See below for an example script.

3

Scene Header INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

JAMES (late-20s) talks softly on the phone, while jotting things down in a notepad.

JAMES
Can I come by tonight?

Action Lines Just then, AMY (mid-20s) walks into the house carrying grocery bags through the front door.

Startled, James hangs up immediately, places the phone on the table and turns to face her.

JAMES (CONT'D)
Hey, you're back so soon.

AMY
(skeptical)
Did you not hear the car pull up in the driveway?

Dialogue JAMES
No. I was watching TV. I didn't hear you. **Character Cue**

AMY
Well, don't just sit there, James.
Help me bring the groceries in.
These are heavy.

James gets up and hurries to take the bags. He walks to the kitchen to put the food away.

DING!

James's phone lights up. Amy notices a text message on his phone. She peers into the kitchen to see James still putting the food away.

AMY (CONT'D)
Put the pork belly in the fridge
and the rest of the meat in the freezer.

JAMES (O.S.)
I got it.

Transition CUT TO:

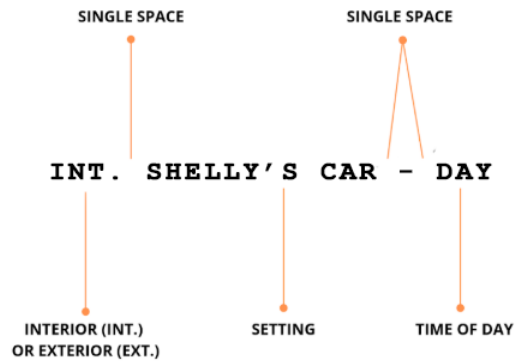
Each component is formatted in specific ways, which we will go over in subsequent chapters.

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2: Scene Headers

Scene Headers inform the reader where the scene is taking place. Is it indoors? Outdoors? Is it taking place during the day or night? There are important information embedded in the scene headers that inform the reader not only about the setting but also the crew members on how to prepare for a shoot.

Scene Headers are formatted as follows:



There are 3 types of Scene Headers are:

1. Master scene heading
2. Secondary scene headings (aka: sub-locations)
3. Special headings/special notations

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2.1: Master Scene Headings

MASTER SCENE HEADINGS

Master scene headings generally have 3 parts, but sometimes a fourth part. Let's go over them.

1. Camera Location
2. Scene Location
3. Time of Day
4. Special Headings

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2.1.1: Camera Location

CAMERA LOCATION

This is the first part of the master scene heading where you indicate whether the camera is located indoors or outdoors. Always use **INT.** for interior and **EXT.** for exterior.

EXT. HOUSE - NIGHT

Alex parks his car in the driveway. He stops at the front door, reaches underneath the welcome mat and pulls out a house key. He enters quietly.

INT. HOUSE - NIGHT

Alex quietly closes the door behind him when suddenly he steps on a LEGO!

Occasionally, the camera will move back and forth between exterior and interior, which can create too many master scene headings. If that's the case, then the following camera notation can be used:

INT./EXT. HOUSE - NIGHT

Alex parks his car in the driveway. He stops at the front door, reaches underneath the welcome mat and pulls out a house key. He enters quietly.

Alex quietly closes the door behind him when suddenly he steps on a LEGO!

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2.1.2: Scene Location

SCENE LOCATION

The second part of the master scene heading denotes where the scene takes place - the location. You generally want to keep it short and specific. For example: JACK'S BEDROOM.

INT. JACK'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Jack sets his backpack down and plops down on the bed exhausted.

Sometimes a simple description could help the director understand that the scene is supposed to be more intimate and budget friendly. We're not trying to describe the scene location in the scene header. A good rule of thumb is to keep it to a few words.

EXT. BUSTLING CITY - DAY

If you need to describe the location in great detail, reserve it for action lines (see example below).

EXT. STREET - DAY

The street is bustling with activity, packed like sardines with people waiting to see the parade.

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2.1.3: Time of Day

TIME OF DAY

The third part of the master scene heading is the time of day, which is most often notated as DAY or NIGHT. This is mainly for production to understand if this is going to be a day shoot or a night shoot, NOT to tell you what specific time it is or what date it is.

If you saw a character walking around in the dark, how would you be able to tell what time of the day it is unless we see a clock or a watch on screen? Therefore, do not put a specific time, such as 6:00AM, as the Time of Day.

DUSK, DAWN, EARLY MORNING, LATE AFTERNOON

Terms like DUSK, DAWN, EARLY MORNING, LATE AFTERNOON or any other words to describe the time of day should only be used if it is necessary to the story and/or the cinematographer. If it is not, then try to avoid using these terms. Another example that is often misused are the terms SUNRISE and SUNSET. Because the scene itself will be shot during the daytime, the correct indication would just be DAY, unless we specifically see a sunrise or a sunset in the scene, as part of the story.

SAME

Sometimes, if the scene takes place at the same time as the previous scene, then SAME will be used.

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

An irate PROFESSOR yells at his students.

INT. HALLWAY - SAME

Jack eavesdrops through the door.

LATER

If the location hasn't changed but time has passed, LATER can be used as an indication of the passage of time.

INT. HOUSE - DAY

Jack falls asleep.

INT. HOUSE - LATER

Jack awakes.

A different way to write this is to just write LATER as a scene header.

INT. HOUSE - DAY

Jack falls asleep.

LATER

Jack awakes.

CONTINUOUS

If a scene happens right after without showing any lapse of time, then CONTINUOUS can be used.

INT. SCHOOL - HALLWAY - DAY

Jack checks his watch and starts sprinting towards his classroom.

INT. SCHOOL - CLASSROOM - CONTINUOUS

Jack runs inside and freezes as the entire class stares back at him.

But, if it's obvious that the scene just follows continuously without any gaps, then it's not always necessary to use CONTINUOUS.

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2.2: Secondary Scene Location

SECONDARY SCENE LOCATION

Secondary scene headings (aka: sub-locations) can be used once a master location has been established. For example, if you have already established the interior of the house (INT. HOUSE) and the camera moves to different rooms within the house, you can add a sub-location as such:

INT. HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

If it starts to become too wordy, you can simply write the sub-location without the camera location or time of day, given that the camera location or the time of day doesn't change.

INT. HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Jack sneaks through the living room so as not to wake anyone.

KITCHEN

He cautiously opens the fridge and grabs a sandwich.

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2.3: Special Headings

SPECIAL HEADINGS

There are other common special notations within the scene headers such as DREAMS, DAYDREAMS, FLASHBACK, INSERT, MONTAGE and etc. They all follow the same basic formatting, but can vary depending on the situation.

MONTAGE

A MONTAGE is a series of images or scenes that are edited together to create a continuous sequence. Here is an example:

INT. BASEBALL FIELD - DAY

Joe is killing it on the pitching mound.

BASEBALL GAME MONTAGE:

... Joe throws strikes after strikes.

... the crowd stands up and cheers with each out.

... frustrated batter snaps his bat in two.

END BASEBALL MONTAGE

To let the reader know that the montage is over, end the montage with either BACK TO SCENE or END MONTAGE.

FLASHBACK and DREAMS

FLASHBACK and DREAM are handled similarly to a MONTAGE. If the scene needs to come back to the present day or the current scene, then you can use PRESENT DAY as a special notation.

EXT. BASEBALL FIELD - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Jack hits the biggest homerun of his life.

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

Jack smiles to himself.

You can also use BACK TO SCENE as a separate slugline to let us know we're back the scene we left off from.

EXT. BASEBALL FIELD - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Jack hits the biggest homerun of his life.

BACK TO SCENE

Jack smiles to himself.

If the scene requires multiple scenes, you can begin a flashback sequence with START FLASHBACK and finish with END FLASHBACK without the need for special notations.

BEGIN FLASHBACK

INT. LOCKER ROOM - DAY

Jack practices swinging in the locker room.

EXT. BASEBALL FIELD - DAY

The pitcher signals to the catcher. Then throws a fastball.

Jack grips his bat and swings!

He hits the biggest homerun of his life.

END FLASHBACK

If your script has a time jump, you could also indicate the year or the season of the scene.

EXT. LONDON STREETS - NIGHT (1875)

INSERT

An INSERT is a “zoom-in” on a specific point of emphasis in a scene. It is often used to draw special attention to something, which could be a picture, letter, book, etc.

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Jack lies on his bed, staring at the ceiling. He reaches into the drawers and takes out a photo.

INSERT - PICTURE

Jack hoisted on the shoulders of his teammates. On the photo, "This was all you, Jack!"

BACK TO SCENE

Jack puts the photo back and falls asleep with a big grin on his face.

When using INSERT, make sure to bring the reader back to the scene by using BACK TO SCENE or by using a new master scene heading.

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3: Action Lines

ACTION LINES

Action Lines are where we see the action happening on screen. In a sense, it's a blueprint of how a movie is going to be made. A general rule is to allow one paragraph per beat of action or image. Write the action as you see it play out on screen. A reader should clearly “see” and “hear” what you are describing. The following are examples that cannot appear on a movie screen and therefore, should not be included in the narrative description.

Jenny stares out the window, thinking about the time she and
Perry went skinny dipping in the lake.

If you were writing a novel, this would be fine but in a visual medium, we aren't privy to certain information, such as inner thoughts. If we simply saw Jenny staring out the window in a movie, how would we know that she's thinking about going skinny dipping in the lake with Perry? This is why it's important to only write action lines that are visual or audible.

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3.1: Best Practices

BEST PRACTICES

While writing styles vary among writers, there are some hard rules as well as certain guidelines you should be aware of.

Present Tense

When writing action lines, you must *always write in the present tense*. A movie is happening in real-time in front of you. Action Lines are actions performed by the actors, like an instruction. Even if there is a flashback in the movie, the flashback itself is happening right before your eyes. Never write verbs in the past tense when writing action lines.

Write Light

When writing action lines, keep in mind to write lightly. Provide only what is necessary to progress the story while emphasizing important actions and moments. Blocks of text can turn off a reader. Write short, crisp sentences. Although writing prose isn't entirely discouraged, just remember that you're not writing a novel.

Only choose details that are important to the story. For example, a character spitting might be irrelevant in a scene, but if the character spits on another character as a sign of disrespect, then maybe that's something to include in the script. Just remember to say as much as you can with as few words as possible. Less is more.

Actions Revealing Character

For the most part, actions should comment on character. If it doesn't add anything to the character or the story, is it really necessary? So let the action reveal something about character and/or about the story.

Instead of this:

Jack looks at Mary.

You could write this:

Jack longingly gazes at Mary.

One sentence reveals something emotional about the way Jack is looking at Mary. The other just feels like he's looking at her.

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3.2: When to use all CAPS

WHEN TO USE ALL CAPS

There are very specific uses for all CAPS specifically when writing action lines. It's used to emphasize something important to the reader, usually one of the following:

1. Sound
2. Prop
3. Direction
4. Character First Appearance

Because scripts are not textbooks, it's easy for the reader to overlook certain things, especially if that person is reading a script on the go. This is why it's important to utilize all CAPS for reasons mentioned above. At the same time, you don't want to use all CAPS too often or it loses its purpose.

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3.2.1: Sound

SOUND

Not everyone sound is important but if it is something integral that needs to be captured in a scene, then you want to make sure to draw the reader's attention to it by using all CAPS. This is especially true in a lot of horror movies when we are not able to see the threat of ghosts or the villain. The director purposely use audio to heighten the tension.

Leslie hears faint FOOTSTEPS in the hallway... just then the door CREAKS open.

It doesn't just have to be more horror scenes, as long as it's important to the story..

Andrew suddenly pauses his game as he hears a loud BANG outside his window.

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3.2.2: Prop

PROP

Likewise, not every prop is an important prop. If you walked into an office, it's customary to see desks, computers, stationaries, etc. But if saw a BLOODY PLUSH DOLL, then it's something that's out of the ordinary setting and hopefully, integral to the story.

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3.2.3: Direction

DIRECTION

There will be times when you want to make sure your audience doesn't miss certain things. It could be a billboard or even an action. In moderations, it's okay to use all CAPS to draw attention to specific actions.

Jack runs down the street and trips over himself, SMASHING his face into the pavement.

Allie cruises down the highway when she sees an EAGLE gliding at eye level.

Important text (ie. signs, news headlines, book titles and etc.) that appear on screen can also be written in CAPS. If the contents of those items need to be shown, you may want to consider using an INSERT.

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3.2.4: Character First Appearance

CHARACTER FIRST APPEARANCE

When a character makes an appearance for the first time, you must use all CAPS on their name. It is usually followed by some form of physical description as well as personality description. The subsequent mentions of the character's name does not need to be in all CAPS.

INT. FANCY RESTAURANT - DAY

Andy impatiently looks around as he waits at his table when
JAMIE (20s) shows up wearing overalls.

Jamie sits at the table, arms crossed, as an act of defiance.

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3.2.4.1: Character Description

CHARACTER DESCRIPTION

When a character first appears in the script, this is where you can describe the character a bit. There's no need to write a whole essay on who this character is or what their backstory is. The name is usually followed by the character's age and the description should suggest something about their nature, which helps the reader as well as the actor gain insight into the character they're seeing.

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

The professor presents a series of mathematical questions on the board.

JERRY (early 20s), a clever but snarky college boy, immediately raises his hand.

The age can be specific depending on the situation. You can say that Tommy is a child but there is a big difference between a 5-year-old and a 10-year-old. Depending on your situation, ask yourself if the readers need to know that a character is specifically 23 or if they just need to know the character is in his early 20s.

On writing physical descriptions, some writers tend to get carried away describing what the character is wearing but unless the clothing serves an important role in the story, you don't need to go into great details. For example, if Sandra is wearing a snow jacket at a ski resort, it's probably standard clothing for cold weathers. But if Sandra is wearing a snow jacket at the beach, then there's probably an important reason why she's doing so.

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3.2.4.2: Naming Characters

NAMING CHARACTERS

All major characters usually have names, including important minor characters but this is not always the case. In *12 Angry Men*, the jurors are simply referred to by their juror numbers throughout most of the film. Whatever you name your character when they first appear, remember to keep it consistent throughout the script, even the character cues.

Characters with maybe just 1 or 2 lines don't always need a name. For example, instead of naming the barista, you can simply introduce them as BARISTA even if they have a speaking line.

If you introduce a group of people, you can number them. For example, if a group of firefighters arrive at the scene of a burning house, you can number the firefighters so as not to create confusion when they are talking:

EXT. HOUSE - DAY

Leslie looks for a way into the burning house.

FIREFIGHTERS arrive and immediately get to work.

FIREFIGHTER #1

Please stay back! It's dangerous!

LESLIE

My cat!

FIREFIGHTER #2

We'll look for your cat. Just stay here.

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3.3: Super

SUPER

When you need to superimpose words on the screen, use SUPER. These are mostly used to inform the reader of a time or place. But sometimes, quotes can be used as well, but if it gets too long, indent it like a dialogue and enclose it with quotations.

EXT. PENTAGON - DAY

SUPER: PENTAGON, WASHINGTON D.C.

Several helicopters hover over the building.

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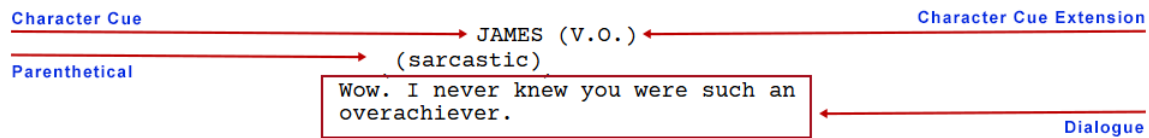
4: Dialogue

DIALOGUE

There are 3 parts of dialogue sections in a screenplay:

1. Character Cue
2. Parentheticals
3. Character's speech (the dialogue)

As a quick refresher, here is an example detailing the breakdown:



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4.1: Character Cue

CHARACTER CUE

The character cue or character name always appears in all CAPS. The character's name should remain the same throughout the entire screenplay.

While character first appearance may have the full name, the character cues are written with their first name only.

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4.2: Character Cue Extension

CHARACTER CUE EXTENSION

Character Cue Extensions appear next to the character cues, mainly to inform the reader of something specific.

The two main uses are:

1. O.S. - Off Screen
2. V.O. - Voiceover

O.S. (Off Screen)

If the character that's speaking is in the location, but just not in the shot, use O.S. to imply they are off screen.

INT. BEDROOM - DAY

Jim sleeps soundly in bed when his Mom starts KNOCKING on the door.

MOM (O.S.)

Jim! It's 7:30! You're going to be late for school!

V.O. (Voice Over)

If the character that is speaking is not in the location or in the shot, then use V.O. for VOICE OVER. This is usually for scenarios where you have a voice in your head or a voiceover narration over a montage or flashback.

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Jim's Mom continues to pound on the door.

MOM

I said you're going to be late!

JIM (V.O.)

Every weekend, she forgets that it's Saturday.

You can also use (V.O.) if there is a person talking on the other line of a telephone call.

Jim's Mom checks the fridge as she juggles the phone and the groceries.

MOM

(into the phone)

Did you take your lunch with you?

JIM (V.O.)

Oh, shoot, I forgot!

ON TV

If a character is speaking on TV, use ON TV as part of the Character Cue Extension. You can substitute TV for whatever alternate medium you might have in your story, such as radio.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Joanne stops dead in her tracks.

ANNOUNCER (ON TV)

It appears that there were no
survivors on the southbound 5
freeway accident.

CONT'D (Continued)

If a character begins to speak and action line breaks up the dialogue and then continues talking again, then use CONT'D.

David takes the glass of wine.

DAVID

They say wine is good for you.

Then he pours it onto the floor.

DAVID (CONT'D)

But then again, I've never enjoyed
the taste of alcohol.

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4.2.1: O.S. (Off Screen)

O.S. (Off Screen)

If the character that's speaking is in the location, but just not in the shot, use O.S. to imply they are off screen.

INT. BEDROOM - DAY

Jim sleeps soundly in bed when his Mom starts KNOCKING on the door.

MOM (O.S.)

Jim! It's 7:30! You're going to be late for school!

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4.2.2: V.O. (Voiceover)

V.O. (Voice Over)

If the character that is speaking is not in the location or in the shot, then use V.O. for VOICE OVER. This is usually for scenarios where you have a voice in your head or a voiceover narration over a montage or flashback.

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Jim's Mom continues to pound on the door.

MOM

I said you're going to be late!

JIM (V.O.)

Every weekend, she forgets that
it's Saturday.

You can also use (V.O.) if there is a person talking on the other line of a telephone call.

Jim's Mom checks the fridge as she juggles the phone and the
groceries.

MOM

(into the phone)

Did you take your lunch with you?

JIM (V.O.)

Oh, shoot, I forgot!

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4.2.3: On TV

ON TV

If a character is speaking on TV, use ON TV as part of the Character Cue Extension. You can substitute TV for whatever alternate medium you might have in your story, such as radio.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Joanne stops dead in her tracks.

ANNOUNCER (ON TV)

It appears that there were no
survivors on the southbound 5
freeway accident.

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4.2.4: CONT'D (Continued)

CONT'D (Continued)

If a character begins to speak and action line breaks up the dialogue and then continues talking again, then use CONT'D.

David takes the glass of wine.

DAVID

They say wine is good for you.

Then he pours it onto the floor.

DAVID (CONT'D)

But then again, I've never enjoyed
the taste of alcohol.

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4.3: Parenthetical

PARENTHETICAL

Parenthetical is a direction or note that are shown in parenthesis in a dialogue. They are sometimes called actor's direction, personal direction or wryly.

The 3 main applications of parentheticals:

1. Convey emotion
2. Action during dialogue
3. When you're addressing someone

These can often provide useful tips, subtext or attitude of the character, but keep in mind to avoid telling your actors how to act. Only use parentheticals when the subtext is not clear.

For example, let's take a simple line of dialogue:

SAMMY
I just love math class.

Without a parenthetical, it just seems like Sammy is stating that she simply loves math class.

SAMMY
(sarcastic)
I just love math class.

Now we know that Sammy is only saying it sarcastically.

You can also add direction to the parenthetical.

SAMMY
(rolling her eyes)
I just love math class.

If there are multiple people in the scene, Sammy can address the dialogue to someone specific.

SAMMY
(to Andrea)
I just love math class.
(to Nancy)
Do you like math?

One thing to note is that you never end the dialogue on a parenthetical. The parenthetical applies to the dialogue beneath it. If there is no dialogue, then there is no point of the parenthetical. If you wanted to sneak in a direction in the parenthetical after the dialogue is over, just use the action line to describe an action for the character.

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4.3.1: Interruption

INTERRUPTION

Sometimes when characters are speaking at the same time, one character might speak over another character or interrupt another speaking character. If that's the case, cut off the previous character's dialogue with a double dash and then use (interruption) or (cutting off) as a parenthetical at the start of the interrupting character's dialogue.

David
Hey that's --
Nancy
(interrupting)
My sandwich.

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4.3.2: Foreign Language

FOREIGN LANGUAGE

When dealing with foreign languages, you can write the dialogue in English but put (in foreign language) in parenthetical.

JAMES

(in Korean)

I don't want to go to school!

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4.4: Beat

BEAT

In screenwriting, Beat is often used to describe a moment of pause. You can write a beat as a parenthetical.

GEORGE
Where's my phone?
(beat)
Oh, yeah. I didn't bring it.

You can also write it as a simple action line.

GEORGE
Where's my phone?
A beat.

GEORGE (CONT'D)
Oh, yeah. I didn't bring it.

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4.5: Simultaneous Talking

SIMULTANEOUS TALKING

If you have 2 or more people speaking at the same time (for the sake of example, let's say Sammy and Andrew), you can simply combine their names in the Character Cues.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Sammy and Andrew run down the stairs, screaming to their mom.

SAMMY AND ANDREW

Mom! Jason broke Mr. Piggy!

If your screenwriting program allows for dual dialogue, this is another way to do it.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Sammy and Andrew run down the stairs, screaming to their mom.

SAMMY ANDREW

Mom! Andrew broke Mr. Piggy! Sammy ate my candies!

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4.6: MORE

MORE

If a dialogue continues from the bottom of one page to the top of the next page, then use MORE at the bottom of the page and then use CONT'D after the character's cue at the top of the next page. Luckily, most screenwriting programs should do this automatically for you.

David sits down across from James.

DAVID
She calls it the happy dagger
because it unites her with her
husband in the afterlife, where
blind prejudice and scorn can't
keep them apart.

James takes off his glasses, stares intently at David.

JAMES
You graduated from an obscure
community college. I put my
daughter through an IVY League.
(MORE)

4.

JAMES (CONT'D)
You're pursuing an unstable career
producing music that worships sex,
drugs and violence while I'm trying
to make sure my daughter spends her
life contributing to society like a
respectable human being.
(beat)
I'd hate to burst your bubble, but
Romeo and Juliet was a story of
vendetta between two families of
equal statures.

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5: Transition

TRANSITION

Transition is a cue to the editor on how scenes should transition. Most of the time, these transitions are not necessary in screenwriting as cuts constantly change in the editing room and that as scenes change, it is largely accepted that the scenes would transition via a cut, rendering the transition CUT TO pointless. Also in spec scripts, it's not advised to write in transitions as directors may have a different creative vision on how to shoot and edit the script.

Still, we will cover the most commonly used transitions so you can understand what they are.

CUT TO:

This is a hard cut or simply a change of scene.

DISSOLVE TO:

This transition is the simultaneous fading out of one scene as the next scene fades in.

FADE IN/FADE OUT

Fade in is the fading into a scene from black. Fade Out is the fading out to a black screen. You can write a Fade In at the start of the script to imply the movie is starting and a Fade Out to imply the end of the movie but even then, it's not necessary in today's writing world.

MATCH CUT TO:

The Match Cut is a transition that uses elements from the previous scene (whether it's visual, audio, or thematic) to seamlessly cut to the next scene, matching the audio, visual or theme in the next scene. A popular example of this is from 2001: A Space Odyssey where a bone thrown in the air match cuts to a rotating satellite in space.

SMASH CUT TO:

The Smash Cut is the cut to a scene that creates a stark contrast between the two scenes. For example, if a character says "I will never do this", then the scene might smash cut to the character doing the very thing they vowed not to do.

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